



THE
QUIETEST
WOUND

TES

He who stands above humanity
eventually dies beneath it.

The Quietest Wound

Tes

— *A novella* —

To feel deeply
is to finally become vulnerable
to life.

On Becoming Human

The Quietest Wound follows the story of an unconquered soul who mistook emotional emptiness for superiority, spending his life conquering others while remaining untouched by humanity itself.

But through a silent and distant love, the man who once stood above feeling slowly collapses into the very emotional void he spent his entire life denying.

The Prussian Campaign

Blood

The first man I killed looked surprised.

Not frightened.

Not angry.

Surprised.

As though death itself had arrived too ordinary to deserve fear.

I remember staring at him while the battlefield continued collapsing around us. Horses screaming somewhere behind the smoke. Steel striking steel in uneven rhythm. Mud swallowing bodies faster than prayers could leave them.

And still, the only thing I noticed was the expression on his face.

I was sixteen then.

Too young to understand guilt.

Young enough to mistake emotional absence for strength.

The Prussian campaign had already consumed thousands before I arrived. Entire villages emptied into smoke and nameless graves while men in decorated uniforms called it strategy rather than slaughter. The older soldiers spoke about war the way exhausted workers speak about weather. Predictable. Necessary. Temporary.

I learned quickly that human beings become frighteningly adaptable once survival begins rewarding cruelty.

By nineteen, I no longer reacted to death at all.

People praised me for it.

Composure.

Discipline.

Control.

They used noble words to describe what was, in reality, emotional starvation.

The battlefield rewards men incapable of hesitation. Mercy slows the hand. Empathy interrupts survival. The soldiers who lived longest were rarely the strongest.

Only the emptiest.

And I was emptier than most.

Kingdoms began recognizing my name after the northern invasions. Villages feared my arrival long before my horse

reached their gates. Younger soldiers watched me with the kind of admiration reserved for myths rather than men.

I understood why.

Violence becomes impressive when witnessed from far enough away.

At the time, I believed fear was the purest form of respect a human being could earn. People obeyed kindness conditionally. Fear demanded nothing except presence.

So, I built myself into something difficult to feel around.

Something untouched.

Something superior.

And for a long time, I truly believed I had succeeded.

The Velmora Massacre

Then came the massacre at Velmora.

Even now, memory approaches it carefully.

As though the mind itself fears reopening something it survived only by refusing to fully understand.

We arrived after sunrise.

The smoke was still rising.

At first, I believed the city had already been abandoned. The streets were too quiet for a place that once carried nearly forty thousand people within its walls. No movement. No voices. Only ash drifting through the air like exhausted snowfall.

Then the horses began refusing to walk forward.

That was when we understood.

Bodies covered the streets so completely that stone itself had disappeared beneath them. Men. Women. Children. Entire families collapsed together exactly where death had reached them. Some had burned inside their homes after the fires spread faster than escape. Others had been executed while trying to flee through the western gates.

And some...

Some had simply been left alive long enough to witness the others die first.

I remember entering what remained of a church near the centre of the city.

Nearly two hundred civilians had hidden there after the bombardment began. The doors had been sealed from the outside before the building was set on fire.

The walls were still blackened when we arrived.

Most of the bodies near the entrance were smaller than my armor.

For the first time in my life, I understood that suffering could exceed human imagination.

Not because of the scale.

Because of the intention behind it.

There are horrors that happen during war.

Then there are horrors created carefully by human beings who have completely detached themselves from humanity itself.

That day, I realized mankind was capable of becoming something worse than violent.

Deliberate.

One of the younger soldiers beside me collapsed before we even reached the altar. Another began vomiting into the ash covered floor while repeating prayers too broken to understand. Even the older men avoided looking directly at the walls.

I felt nothing.

Not disgust.

Not grief.

Not rage.

Nothing.

And standing there surrounded by enough suffering to break entire generations of people, I finally understood what I had truly become.

Not strong.

Wrong.

Because no human being should remain emotionally untouched after witnessing something like that.

Yet I did.

Completely.

As though every wall I had built inside myself had become too thick for reality itself to penetrate.

The Fall of Ardenhal

Kingdoms do not collapse all at once.

First, trade disappears.

Then borders.

Then hope.

By the time war finally reaches the capital,
most nations are already corpses
pretending to remain alive.

Ardenhal lasted longer than anyone
expected.

Perhaps that was why its destruction
became so absolute.

The invasion began before dawn.

Entire battalions emerged from the southern valleys beneath black banners dark enough to disappear into the morning fog itself. By sunrise, the outer districts were already burning. The royal guard fought desperately to hold the eastern gates while civilians flooded through the streets searching for places no longer capable of protecting them.

The king refused evacuation.

I remember that clearly.

Even while advisors begged him to flee toward the northern territories, he remained standing inside the throne hall wearing armor too heavy for a man his age.

“There is no kingdom beyond this city,” he said.

Three hours later, they brought me his head.

After that, something inside the capital broke permanently.

War at that scale no longer resembles battle. It becomes weather. Entire streets disappear beneath fire before soldiers even realize where death is coming from.

Commands dissolve into screaming.

Horses crush the wounded beneath panic.

Men kill each other without seeing faces.

And at the centre of all of it,

Was me.

By then, my name alone carried enough fear to move armies. Soldiers avoided meeting my eyes during combat the way deeply religious people avoid looking directly at death.

I carved through men faster than memory could preserve them. Steel entered flesh so often that violence itself became rhythm rather than action.

I killed more people that day than I could count.

I saved none.

That truth remained with me longer than the war itself.

Because beneath all the blood and collapsing towers and endless noise, the only thing I truly accomplished was survival.

Nothing noble.

Nothing heroic.

Only survival.

Near nightfall, the inner walls finally collapsed.

The enemy forces flooded into the capital like water breaking through weakened stone. The remaining soldiers around me died faster than replacements could arrive. One lost his jaw beside me before I even heard the arrow. Another continued fighting for nearly thirty seconds after being disembowelled.

Human beings are horrifyingly unwilling to die.

I remember the first blade entering my side.

Then another beneath my ribs.

Then one through my shoulder deep enough to force the sword from my hand.

After that, the battlefield became
fragments.

Mud.

Smoke.

Blood inside my mouth.

The sound of burning wood collapsing
somewhere behind me.

Someone drove steel into my back while I
was already on the ground.

Another into my stomach.

I stopped counting after that.

The strange thing about nearing death is
how quickly pride abandons the body.

Titles disappear. Reputation disappears.

Superiority disappears. Beneath enough
suffering, all human beings become
painfully equal.

And lying there among thousands of
corpses beneath the burning remains of
Ardenhal, I realized something I had spent
my entire life avoiding.

For all the kingdoms I had conquered...

For all the men I had killed...

For all the fear my name inspired...

Not a single person came back for me.

I had spent my entire life standing above
humanity.

So, when death finally reached for me,

There was no one beside me at all.

Her

That was when I saw her.

Not dramatically.

Not the way dying men describe miracles
afterward to make survival sound
meaningful.

She was simply there.

Moving through the aftermath of the
battlefield with a lantern in one hand and
blood covering the sleeves of her coat.
Around us, Ardenhal continued collapsing
into smoke and ruin while exhausted
survivors searched the dead for names they
hoped not to recognize.

And somehow, in the middle of all that
destruction,

She looked painfully alive.

I remember watching her kneel beside
wounded soldiers without hesitation.

Enemy soldiers. Our soldiers. It did not
seem to matter to her. She moved between
suffering bodies with the same quiet
urgency people reserve for things they still
believe are worth saving.

I could not understand it.

The world had just revealed its true nature
as clearly as possible. Kingdoms burned.
Men butchered each other beneath
banners and prayers. Entire lives vanished
between sunrise and nightfall.

And still,

She chose kindness.

At first, I mistook it for naivety.

Only weak people preserve softness in a world that punishes it.

That was what I believed then.

Yet even while thinking it, I found myself unable to look away from her.

Perhaps because she appeared untouched by the emotional starvation, I had spent my entire life mistaking for superiority.

There was no performance in her movements. No desire to appear noble.

She simply helped people because suffering reached her in ways it no longer reached me.

Or perhaps never had.

Eventually, she noticed me among the bodies.

For a moment, her eyes met mine.

Not fearfully.

Not admiringly.

Just humanly.

And for reasons I could not explain at the
time,

That frightened me more than death ever
had.

Silence

I lost consciousness sometime before midnight.

When I opened my eyes again, the war was gone.

Or perhaps merely distant enough to sound unreal.

Rain pressed softly against the windows beside me. Somewhere nearby, firewood cracked beneath low flames. The air carried the scent of damp cloth, medicine, and something strangely unfamiliar after years spent surviving battlefields.

Peace.

For several moments, I genuinely believed
I had died.

Then the pain returned.

Slowly.

Violently.

Every movement felt stitched together by
knives. My ribs burned whenever I
breathed too deeply. Bandages wrapped
around most of my body beneath blankets
rough enough to scrape against the skin.

I remember turning my head slightly,

And seeing her.

She sat near the far side of the room beside
a lantern dim enough to leave half her face
hidden in shadow. Blood stained her
sleeves from treating the wounded.

Exhaustion rested visibly beneath her eyes, yet her hands continued moving carefully between bowls of water and torn cloth as though rest itself had become unimportant to her.

For a long moment, neither of us spoke.

Not because something prevented it.

Words simply felt strangely unnecessary.

I watched her clean blood from hands that were not her own. Watched her exhaustion continue long after most people would have surrendered to it. Watched the quiet patience in her movements while she repaired damage created by men like me.

And somewhere inside myself,

Something shifted.

Not dramatically.

Human beings rarely transform through sudden revelation. Most changes arrive quietly enough to remain unnoticed until long after they have already begun.

She eventually approached the bed after noticing I was awake.

For a brief moment, her eyes met mine again.

There was still no fear inside them.

No admiration either.

Only concern.

Pure.

Uncalculated.

Human concern.

I had spent my entire life understanding people through hierarchy. Fear. Power. Utility. Weakness.

Every relationship I had ever witnessed depended upon transaction somehow.

Yet nothing in her expression asked anything from me at all.

That confused me more deeply than war ever had.

She changed the bandages around my side carefully, avoiding the deeper wounds near my ribs. Her hands trembled slightly from exhaustion. Once, while tightening the cloth near my shoulder, pain forced a sharp breath from me before I could suppress it.

For the first time in years...

Someone looked at my suffering as though it mattered.

Not strategically.

Not politically.

Not ceremonially.

Just... genuinely.

And still, not a single word passed between us.

Yet somehow, that silence felt heavier than every conversation I had endured throughout my entire life.

The First Fear

That night, sleep refused to reach me.

Pain moved beneath my body slowly, like fire trapped underneath the skin itself.

Every wound pulsed with enough force to remind me I was still alive, though I could not decide whether that knowledge comforted me or not.

The room remained quiet except for the rain beyond the windows.

And her.

She had fallen asleep sometime after midnight while sitting beside the chair near the lantern. Exhaustion had finally succeeded where responsibility failed.

One of her hands still rested loosely against the edge of the bed, as though even unconsciousness had not fully separated her from the wounded she spent her nights saving.

I remember staring at her longer than I should have.

Not because of beauty.

At least, not entirely.

It was something else.

Something quieter.

There was a softness around her existence that felt deeply unfamiliar to me. The battlefield had spent years teaching me that survival required distance from humanity. Yet she moved through suffering without protecting herself from it at all.

And somehow,

She remained kind.

I could not understand how.

My entire life, I had mistaken emotional detachment for intelligence. Men who cared too deeply broke first. Empathy clouded judgment. Attachment created weakness.

That was what war had taught me.

Then why did she appear stronger than every soldier I had ever known?

The thought unsettled me enough that I almost laughed.

That was when I saw the snake.

It moved silently through the shadows near the corner of the room, slow enough to remain almost invisible beneath the lanternlight. Its body slid carefully across the wooden floor toward her chair with the quiet patience only dangerous things possess.

Ordinarily, I would not have reacted at all.

Fear and I had stopped recognizing each other years ago.

I had stood inside burning cities.

Walked across battlefields covered in bodies.

Watched men die slowly enough to beg for death before it finally reached them.

A snake should have meant nothing to me.

Yet suddenly,
My heart moved.
Violently.
Not for myself.
For her.

The realization struck harder than the
battlefield ever had.

Before thought could interrupt instinct, my
hand moved toward the knife still hidden
near the back of my ankle. She must have
forgotten to remove it while treating my
wounds.

For the first time in my life, fear made my
body move faster than violence ever had.

I pulled the blade free and threw it.

The knife crossed past her shoulder so quickly the air itself seemed to split around it before embedding deep into the wooden wall behind the chair.

The snake collapsed instantly.

Her eyes opened at once.

The sudden movement of air.

The sound of steel entering wood.

The instinctive awareness that something dangerous had passed impossibly close to her.

For several seconds, neither of us moved.

She stared toward the knife.

Then toward the dead snake beneath it.

Then finally,

At me.

And sitting there beneath the dim
lanternlight, breathing harder than I ever
had during war itself, I understood
something terrifying.

For the first time in my life,
I had been afraid to lose someone.

The Escape

Snakes were common throughout the eastern territories.

The winters drove them toward warmth. Houses. Barns. Shelters built too close to the forests. Most people living there learned quickly that fear alone accomplished very little against nature.

She removed the snake quietly.

No panic.

No trembling.

Only calm exhaustion.

After pulling the knife free from the wall, she wrapped the dead creature in cloth before wiping the blood from the wooden floorboards with the same patience she seemed to offer every terrible thing around her.

Then, after several moments of silence, she looked toward me.

“Would you like some soup?”

Her voice surprised me more than the battlefield had.

Soft.

Not weak.

Not timid.

Just... gentle.

“We have both eaten nothing today.”

For reasons I still struggle to explain, I suddenly found myself incapable of speaking correctly.

I had commanded armies.

Negotiated treaties.

Ordered executions without hesitation.

Yet a simple question from her left my thoughts disorganized enough to feel almost humiliating.

“Yes,” I managed eventually.

Even then, the word emerged unevenly.

She disappeared briefly into the next room before returning with two bowls of soup balanced carefully in her hands. One for herself. One for me.

And for the next several minutes, we sat together beneath the lanternlight in complete silence.

Eating.

No conversation.

No introductions.

No attempt to fill the quiet between us.

Strangely,

It was the most peaceful silence I had ever experienced.

Most silence between people feels empty somehow. Awkward. Forced. Human beings usually rush to bury it beneath unnecessary words before discomfort fully arrives.

But the silence around her felt different.

Complete.

As though neither of us needed language to justify the other's presence there.

Days passed this way afterward.

Quietly.

She treated my wounds each morning while rain pressed softly against the windows beside us. Sometimes she read near the lantern while I rested. Sometimes she disappeared briefly to gather supplies from the nearby villages before returning before nightfall.

And somehow, without understanding when it happened...

I began waiting for her footsteps.

The realization disturbed me deeply.

Attachment had always seemed dangerous to me. Dependence even more so. I spent most of my life building walls high enough to prevent other people from reaching anything real inside me.

Yet around her, those walls no longer felt impenetrable.

Only tired.

Then the soldiers arrived.

Ardenhal had officially fallen three days earlier. The remaining enemy forces had begun moving through nearby territories searching homes and shelters for survivors connected to the former kingdom.

Traitors.

Soldiers.

Witnesses.

People like me.

I heard them before I saw them. Horses outside. Heavy boots against frozen ground.

Voices carrying the careless confidence men often develop after victory removes consequences from their behaviour.

Then the door opened.

For several seconds, nobody moved.

One of the soldiers recognized me first.

The expression on his face changed immediately.

Fear.

Then violence followed it.

The fight erupted too quickly for thought itself to fully form around it. My body still carried wounds deep enough to reopen with every movement, yet instinct overtook pain before weakness could. Steel entered flesh again. Men collapsed against the walls beside me.

Blood covered the floorboards faster than
memory could preserve details.

I do not remember how many I killed.

Only that survival once again demanded
brutality before humanity.

By the end, breathing itself felt difficult.

That was when I saw her outside.

She was near the far field beyond the trees,
guiding one of the horses through uneven
ground beneath the rain. The moment her
eyes found the blood behind me,

She understood.

No words.

No hesitation.

Only understanding.

The remaining soldiers would return soon with more men. Staying meant death for both of us.

I had no strength left to fight another battle.

So, I ran toward her.

The moment I reached the horse, I pulled myself behind her despite the pain tearing through my body hard enough to blur my vision. For a brief second, I expected questions.

Instead,

She tightened her grip on the reins and forced the horse forward.

And together, we disappeared into the rain before the kingdom could finish burying itself behind us.

The Life Beyond Blood

We rode through the rain until the kingdom behind us disappeared completely.

For most of the journey, neither of us spoke.

The horse moved unevenly beneath us while distant thunder followed somewhere beyond the forests. My wounds reopened long before sunrise. Several times, blood stained the side of my coat heavily enough that I nearly lost consciousness again.

Yet every time my body weakened against her back,

She slowed the horse slightly.

As though silently reminding me not to die yet.

By the third day, we finally crossed the western borders into Elaris.

The kingdom itself felt strangely untouched by war. No smoke rising beyond the hills. No frightened civilians gathering supplies before inevitable invasion. No soldiers dragging exhaustion behind their eyes like chains.

Peace still existed there.

I remember finding that difficult to believe.

The guards near the gates allowed us entry almost immediately after seeing my condition. Several villagers rushed toward us before questions even began.

Someone helped me from the horse while
others guided her toward shelter beneath
the rain.

It happened gradually afterward.

The misunderstanding.

At first, I did not notice it.

The way people looked at us.

The assumptions hidden quietly inside
their kindness.

A wounded man arriving beside a woman
who refused to leave him.

Human beings naturally create love
wherever loyalty survives suffering.

She corrected them eventually.

Gently.

“We are not married,” she explained once after an elderly woman referred to me as her husband.

The woman only smiled afterward.

As though some forms of closeness mattered more than titles.

Strangely,

I found myself unable to speak during moments like that.

Not because I wished the misunderstanding to continue.

At least, that is what I told myself then.

The people of Elaris treated us with a kindness I had never experienced before. Food arrived without request. Rooms were prepared before we asked for shelter.

Children waved toward her whenever she crossed the market streets carrying medicine or supplies.

And every day, I watched her move through ordinary life with the same quiet gentleness she once carried through battlefields.

That was when I began noticing beauty in things I had ignored my entire life.

The way she lowered her voice around frightened children.

The way stray animals approached her without fear.

The exhaustion hidden behind her eyes after helping people all day while still pretending she was not tired.

The way she stood near windows whenever it rained.

None of it was extraordinary.

Perhaps that was exactly why it affected me so deeply.

War had taught me to admire power.
Violence. Dominance. Survival.

Yet somehow, the quiet humanity inside ordinary moments now felt far more powerful than conquest ever had.

One night, while replacing the bandages around my shoulder, I apologized to her.

The words felt unnatural leaving my mouth.

“I am sorry,” I said quietly.

Not for one thing.

For all of it.

The blood.

The violence.

The war that followed me into her life the moment we met.

She looked at me silently for several seconds afterward.

Then continued wrapping the bandages gently, as though she understood every word I failed to say aloud.

It frightened me how much peace existed inside her silence.

Weeks passed.

Then months.

Eventually, my body healed enough for training again. Word of my past spread through Elaris slowly after several soldiers recognized my name. By winter, the royal court itself requested my presence.

The king offered me command over the kingdom's highest military order.

Years earlier, I would have accepted before the sentence finished.

Power once felt inseparable from identity to me. Men spent entire lifetimes killing each other for titles they mistook for meaning.

But sitting there inside the throne hall, listening to people praise my violence as though it were something noble,

I felt tired.

Truly tired.

For the first time in my life, I understood that blood does not disappear once war ends. It follows people. Into kingdoms. Into homes. Into the quietest parts of themselves.

And I could not allow it to follow me any further.

So, I refused.

The court seemed shocked.

Perhaps because men like me were not expected to walk away from power willingly.

But the truth was painfully simple.

I no longer wanted to become the kind of man she would have feared meeting on a battlefield.

The Quietness of Living

Peace exhausted me more than war ever had.

That realization disturbed me deeply.

Violence was simple. Survival reduced humanity into instinct eventually. People became predictable once fear entered them strongly enough. War stripped existence down to its ugliest truths until all that remained was hunger, brutality, and the desperate desire to remain alive another day.

But ordinary life,

Ordinary life required something far more difficult.

Presence.

The people of Elaris woke each morning expecting tomorrow to arrive. Farmers repaired fences they believed would still matter years later. Merchants argued over prices insignificant enough to seem meaningless after witnessing kingdoms collapse. Children laughed loudly through market streets without understanding how fragile the world truly was.

And somehow, despite everything I had survived,

I envied them.

I spent most mornings near the stables after my wounds healed completely. The horses there had grown strangely comfortable around me over time. Animals do not care about reputation. They respond only to what exists directly in front of them. Calmness. Violence. Fear.

Perhaps human beings should have remained more like them.

She often worked near the southern district treating labourers injured during construction or helping elderly villagers unable to travel alone. Sometimes I accompanied her silently through the streets carrying supplies while she moved from house to house beneath the afternoon rain.

Children began recognizing her instantly.

Some ran toward her the moment they saw her approaching.

Others simply smiled.

And every single time,

She smiled back.

Not performatively.

Not politely.

Genuinely.

I remember noticing once how differently people looked at her compared to me.

Around me, people remained respectful.

Careful. Slightly guarded beneath their kindness.

Around her,

People relaxed.

As though her existence itself allowed them to feel safe.

The realization stayed with me longer than I expected.

Fear had followed me my entire life. I once considered that power.

Respect built from intimidation felt efficient to me. Reliable. Men obeyed dangerous things naturally.

Yet watching people trust her so effortlessly forced an uncomfortable question into my mind.

What if gentleness reached people more deeply than fear ever could?

The thought alone would have disgusted the man I used to be.

One evening, rain began heavily enough to trap us beneath the roof of an old storage building near the marketplace. She sat quietly beside the doorway listening to the storm while exhausted workers hurried through the streets outside searching for shelter.

“You dislike rain,” she said suddenly.

The words startled me enough that I almost looked around to confirm she had spoken to me.

It was the first real conversation between us.

“I do not dislike it,” I answered eventually.

“You watch it like someone remembering something painful.”

I fell silent after that.

Not because she was wrong.

Because she was frighteningly close to understanding me.

For several moments, neither of us spoke again. Rain continued striking the rooftops around us while distant thunder rolled softly across the kingdom beyond the hills.

Then she spoke once more.

“War took my parents during winter,” she said quietly. “Since then, storms make people seem temporary to me.”

There are moments in life where another person’s pain enters you so suddenly that your own thoughts stop existing for a while.

This was one of them.

I turned toward her instinctively.

Not strategically.

Not analytically.

Humanly.

And for the first time in my life,

Someone else’s suffering hurt me more than my own.

The Quietest Wound

By spring, my body had almost completely healed.

The scars remained, of course.

War always leaves evidence behind eventually. Sometimes on flesh. Sometimes somewhere far more permanent.

I began taking small jobs throughout Elaris afterward. Repairing fences near the northern farms. Carrying supplies between districts. Helping stable workers during colder mornings when the horses grew restless before rain.

Ordinary work.

The kind of life I once would have considered beneath me.

Strangely,

It felt more honest than conquest ever had.

The people there slowly stopped recognizing me as a soldier. To them, I became simply another quiet man moving through the kingdom without asking much from the world around him.

And for the first time in my life, I found myself relieved by anonymity.

She remained the same.

That was perhaps the most beautiful thing about her.

The world changed constantly around her. Seasons passed. Kingdoms shifted. Entire lives entered and disappeared from the streets of Elaris.

Yet her kindness never seemed
performative enough to weaken with time.

She still smiled at frightened children the
same way.

Still exhausted herself helping strangers
who could offer nothing in return.

Still looked at suffering as though human
pain deserved attention rather than
explanation.

And somewhere between ordinary
mornings and quiet evenings beneath rain-
soaked rooftops,

I realized I had fallen in love with her.

Not suddenly.

Love rarely arrives dramatically in real life.

It grows quietly through repetition.

Through presence. Through small
moments that seem meaningless

individually before eventually becoming impossible to live without.

The way she tucked loose strands of hair behind her ear while reading.

The softness in her voice after long days.

The unconscious habit she had of watching storms through windows in silence.

None of it should have mattered as deeply as it did.

Yet somehow,

She had become the calmest part of my existence.

That realization frightened me less than it should have.

Perhaps because by then, I already understood something painful long before admitting it to myself.

We were never going to belong to each other.

Not tragically.

Not cruelly.

Simply truthfully.

Some people enter our lives not to remain beside us forever, but to quietly change the direction of who we become while passing through them.

She had done that to me long ago.

And strangely, understanding this did not lessen what I felt for her.

It only made it quieter.

Eventually, I moved from the house we shared.

Not because anything happened between us.

Nothing ever did.

But people talk. Human beings become uncomfortable around forms of closeness they cannot define properly. I noticed the way villagers looked at us sometimes. The assumptions hidden beneath their smiles.

And for reasons I could not fully explain, I wanted to protect her even from misunderstanding.

So, I found a small abandoned house near the old swamps beyond the eastern fields. The roof leaked during heavier storms. Frogs filled the nights with endless noise during summer. Most people avoided the area entirely after sunset because the marshlands carried a reputation for loneliness difficult to explain rationally.

I think that was why I chose it.

Loneliness had always recognized me
easily.

Life settled into quiet routine afterward.

I worked.

I slept.

I watched rain gather over the swamps
during colder evenings.

And sometimes, when the distance
between our homes no longer felt
unbearable,

I visited her.

Never for long.

Sometimes we spoke.

Sometimes we did not.

Yet every silence beside her still carried the
same strange peace it always had.

Years passed this way.

Slowly.

Humanly.

And despite understanding that nothing more would ever exist between us, I never stopped loving her.

Not desperately.

Not hopelessly.

Just quietly.

The strange thing about becoming human is realizing that love does not always ask to be possessed in order to remain real.

Sometimes it simply exists. Softly.

Permanently. Like rain against windows or scars beneath skin.

I once believed emotions made people weak.

Now, I think the inability to feel them honestly is what truly empties a person.

She never became mine.

Yet somehow, she became the most
human part of me.

And perhaps,

That was enough.

Perhaps the saddest part of
human connection
is how deeply someone can
change us
without ever knowing they
did.